the cost of marketing elsewhere); students forge long-term corporate loyalties (an average of at least fifteen years for credit cards); and their present and future needs include a wide-range of financial services (private student loans, debt consolidation loans, checking accounts, savings accounts, auto loans, and home mortgages). Finally, unlike other nearly saturated credit card "niche" markets, at least one-third of the population of four-year colleges and universities are replenished each year with new students (freshmen and transfers).

The reality is that the United States is a free market society, and when someone is of a legal age, they can be pursued as a customer and held responsible for their debts. This means that as a college student, you will continue to be sought after by credit card companies and other financial institutions. Remember that just because you are offered a credit card doesn't mean that you have to accept it.

Christi's problems all started as a freshman when she found a credit card application that had been placed in her bag at Florida State University's bookstore. She did not have a credit card and thought it would be smart to have one for emergencies. She was far from home, having been born and raised in Illinois, and she felt safer having a credit card in her possession. Unfortunately, Christi's definition of an emergency included meals out, party clothes, and football tickets. She enjoyed going out with her friends, which soon became a daily occurrence.

When she reached the limit on her first credit card she easily obtained another application from a credit card company's booth outside the student union. Christi even got a water bottle and a beach towel for filling out the application. When this card also became charged to the max, Christi went back to the student union and this time got a T-shirt along with her third credit card.

Before it even seemed possible, Christi had accumulated $10,000 on her three credit cards. She never kept track of her